

The Tech Way



Let's do something on
Mind Mapping

Most mind mapping software lets you easily highlight ideas using special icons and colours

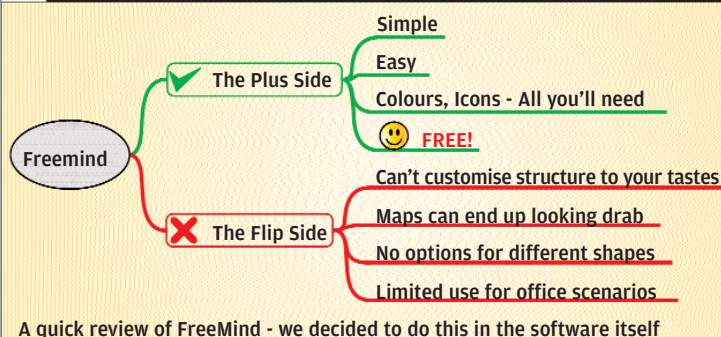
even the art of mind mapping has found its way here. The unfortunate part about mind mapping on paper is that the size of the paper sometimes just isn't enough for complex maps. Things can get quite messy, trying to squeeze in a thought here and an idea there, and we don't really want to have the additional burden of planning out space on a sheet of paper. And in the mad rush of our lives today, we shouldn't have to sit with coloured pens and pencils to make the mind map more engrossing.

Mind mapping software tools have become quite powerful today, while still keeping in mind that people need to do this really quickly. No matter how complex your mind map becomes, it will always be neat and you'll never be short of space. Creating sub-topics or topics at the same level is usually mapped to an easy keyboard shortcut, so you don't need to keep switching between keyboard and mouse. Adding colours and images is just a couple of mouse clicks away, so there's no need to rely on your (probably appalling) drawing skills. Mind map getting too big? The maps are built as tree structures—you can collapse or expand your sub-topics so you only see what you want to.

Your Happy Helpers

There are many tools out there to help you make mind maps—from the simple, free ones to the *really* powerful that cost as much as \$250 (Rs 11,500)! A free tool that caught our eye was FreeMind, which is simple, neat, and very easy to use. It offers all you might need—special icons, colours, and even a 'cloud' that encloses each line of thought. Extremely useful, we

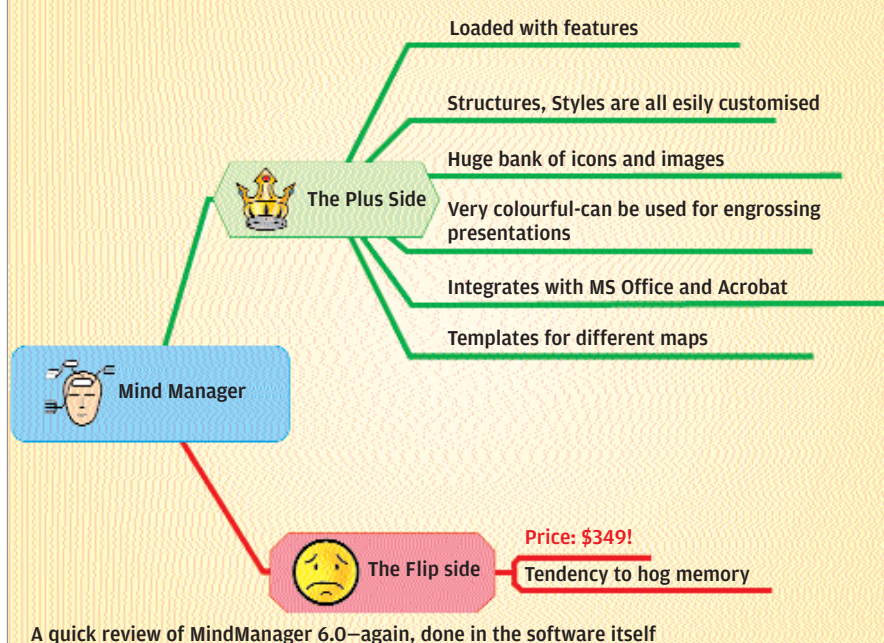
FreeMind 0.8.0



think, for the individual. However, your mind map can only have a very simple layout—it doesn't allow you to play with the structure. The keyboard shortcuts are easy to learn and quite logically placed.

For someone looking to incorporate mind maps as a business tool, we found Mindjet MindManager quite impressive. It allows for huge flexibility in the structure of the map, and also provides templates for different types of business scenarios—meetings, decision making, to-do lists, and the like. It also provides numerous options to make your mind map visually appealing, so can be used to make some very interesting presentations.

MindManager 6.0



You can find both these on this month's Digit CD and DVD.

If you're off the beaten track, FreeMind also comes in a Linux and Mac OS flavour as well—try <http://freemind.sourceforge.net>. In the paid category, you would find ConceptDraw MINDMAP and Softneuron Mindmap for your alternative OS needs. Both of these can be ordered from <http://www.mapyourmind.com/macintosh.htm> (don't let the link fool you—the page is actually for Mac and Linux)

Old Way, Tech Way

We love technology here at Digit, but sometimes even we must concede to the old way. True, mind mapping software has taken an already popular concept to new heights, but at the end of it all, there really is no substitute to seeing your ideas laid out in your own hand. There is a special joy in getting involved in drawing your own mind map—something software cannot offer. So if you're going to be using a mind map, we recommend software to get things done quick; but really, you should get your hands dirty once in a while. ☒

nimesh_chandiramani@thinkdigit.com